

ID: SOMA-M-P06

Title: Awareness of Breath

Duration: 10m 00s (**705** words)

Script Content:

[Practice]

When you're ready, let's begin this practice.

Today we'll explore what it is like to intentionally pay attention to our breath. The invitation is to follow the natural rhythm of your breath. There is no need to change the way you are breathing. This practice is about observing, not controlling.

You can use the contact of your feet on the floor or your body on the chair as an anchor. This provides a sense of grounding. Feel free to use this anchor if you get distracted, or if focusing on the breath becomes uncomfortable. We are not looking for anything special or unusual in the breath.

Find a position where you feel steady and comfortable, but awake – sitting or standing, or lying down. Your eyes can be open or closed. Later in the practice, you might experiment with opening or closing your eyes. Notice if the breath feels different. Now, bring your attention to your body in this posture. Take a moment to find where you feel the movement of the breath most clearly.

[Short Pause] (10s - Finding the anchor)

Some examples include the rising and falling of your chest or the abdomen, the gentle flow of air at the nostrils or the mouth. Perhaps in other parts of the body as well, such as the sides of your body making subtle contact with your lower arms. All locations are equally valid, simply noticing with a friendly curiosity.

[Long Pause] (20s - Observation practice)

With an invitation now to choose which of these places you may wish to rest your attention on for this practice.

And then, in this place, simply noticing the natural movement of the breath. The coming and going. Noticing any physical sensations that accompany this process. Perhaps the slight difference in temperature of the breath – cool on the in-breath and slightly warmer on the out-breath. Perhaps noticing the tiny pause between an in-breath and an out-breath.

Being gentle with yourself as you explore. Not chasing sensations. As best you can, bringing an open interest to all this. And if any part of your experience becomes too uncomfortable, feeling free to pause this practice.

[Long Pause] (30s - Deepening focus)

And if a deeper breath naturally arrives, using this too as an opportunity to notice any physical sensations that come with it. Do your shoulders move just that little bit more? Does your rib cage seem to expand just those extra few millimeters? Or perhaps, when a deeper breath arises, you suddenly notice the breath in different places at once, such as the nostrils and the chest?

And after a deeper breath took place, returning now to observing the natural rhythm of your breath.

[Short Pause] (10s - Natural rhythm)

We are learning to rest with and pay attention to the natural flow of the breath – however it is in this moment.

[Short Pause] (10s - Breath awareness)

Awareness of one breath at a time. Following the movements of the breath, the physical sensations of the breath.

[Short Pause] (10s - In-breath/Out-breath)

What is this breath like?

And what is this breath like? Not thinking about the breath, but sensing.

[Long Pause] (30s - Sensing the breath)

Full awareness of the in-breath. Full awareness of the out-breath. One breath at a time.

From time to time, you might notice your mind getting distracted. Perhaps by sounds around you or by your own thoughts. This is entirely natural and not a mistake. Each time your attention wanders, simply acknowledge it. Treat the distraction and yourself with kindness, and then bring your attention back to the breath.

[Short Pause] (10s - Re-focusing)

Resting your attention on the body, breathing in, breathing out.

With no two breaths ever exactly the same, noticing how sensations may be different too. What details or variations might be here to explore? Perhaps a lightness or heaviness across the chest, perhaps becoming aware of any back muscles that are involved in breathing? Or something else that is here to explore?

[Short Pause] (10s - Sustained curiosity)

Now, we will slowly bring this practice to a close. Spend a few moments simply being with the breath. Try to get a sense of the whole body breathing, feeling the air move in and out of your entire body.

[Pause] (20s - Final integration)

And then once more intentionally sensing into the points of contact between the body and the floor and the surface you are resting on. Taking a deeper breath or two if you like, and then opening your eyes if they were closed.

Thank you for your practice.

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